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SpaceX | North America

Starship Flight 13 Report Card: A Clear Positive in a Tide of Cautious Sentiment

While admittedly a qualitative assessment, if we're asked to assign a grade to SpaceX's **Starship Flight 13** we would give it an overall grade of **A-**. While not a entirely flawless, **Flight 13** included some extraordinary milestones that should leave investors with greater conviction in Starship's path to becoming operational. Most notably, Musk posted shortly after the flight that SpaceX will likely attempt its first-ever Ship catch on Flight 14, giving investors one of the first concrete potential upside catalysts to anticipate. Bears will isolate the off-nominal booster landing burn as reason for caution, but this was only the second landing attempt of a V3 booster and its all-new Raptor 3 propulsion, so a hard landing should not be a major surprise, and it still marked a clear step up from Flight 12 when the V3 booster was lost before it ever reached a landing. First lockup release after August 4 earnings is still an overhang, which likely keeps many would-be longs on the sidelines. **Overall stock implications: Positive. Next milestone... catching ship. If they can do that, bears may need to consider cryogenic hibernation.**

Report Card in 7 Parts:

- 1. **Countdown and launch readiness (B):** Recovered from a T-0 pad abort on Jul 16 (moisture in the LOX turbopumps kept four Raptors from starting; six engines swapped), then went cleanly on July 24th. There was a scrub on July 23rd due to poor visibility from weather, but that was out of SpaceX's control.
- 2. **Liftoff and ascent (A+):** All 33 Super Heavy Raptors lit in a clean, full-thrust ascent with no engine-out.
- 3. **Hot-stage separation (A+):** Clean hot-stage separation and stage split, with no repeat of the ~90° flip that doomed the Flight 12 booster.
- 4. **Boostback & landing burn (C+):** Boostback was clean, but the final landing burn lit only ~5 of 13 engines, forcing a hard splashdown in the Gulf of America. No catch was planned, but a soft touchdown is a prerequisite before any future tower catch of the V3 Booster.
- 5. **Payload deployment (A+):** First-ever deployment of 20 production Starlink V3 satellites (prior flights carried simulators). Arrays and antennas extended, laser links to the constellation successful. Satellites de-orbited shortly after as was planned- these sats weren't intended to serve customers. Satellites captured extensive imagery of the ship heatshield after deployment.
- 6. **In-space maneuvers/Raptor relight (A+):** Successful single-engine relight ~39 min into flight. This was the maneuver test abandoned on Flight 12 due to the loss of a Raptor vacuum engine on the ship.

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SpaceX (SPCX.O, SPCX US)					
Space Technology United States of America					
Stock Rating	Overweight				
Industry View	Attractive				
Price target	\$300.00				
Shr price, close (Jul 24, 2026)	\$115.07				
52-Week Range	\$225.64-110.85				
Fiscal Year Ending	12/25	12/26e	12/27e	12/28e	
EPS (\$)**	(1.69)	0.28	2.18	6.29	
Prior EPS (\$)**	-	-	-	-	
P/E	NM	406.4	52.7	18.3	
EPS (\$)	-	(0.42)	0.61	3.12	
Div yld (%)	-	0.0	0.0	0.0	

Unless otherwise noted, all metrics are based on Morgan Stanley ModelWare framework
** = Based on consensus methodology
\$ = Consensus data is provided by Refinitiv Estimates
e = Morgan Stanley Research estimates

QUARTERLY EPS (\$)					
Quarter	2025	2026e Prior	2026e Current	2027e Prior	2027e Current
Q1	(0.18)	-	(0.84)a	-	0.54
Q2	(0.34)	-	(0.35)	-	0.55
Q3	(0.36)	-	0.27	-	0.54
Q4	(0.80)	-	0.45	-	0.56

e = Morgan Stanley Research estimates, a = Actual Company reported data

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7. **Ship reentry, heat shield & splashdown (A+):** Cleared peak heating and max-Q, then SpaceX's softest splashdown ever: no explosion, ship intact, floating and transmitting telemetry in the Indian Ocean allowing for SpaceX to capture high quality imagery of nearly the entire heatshield. Some damaged tiles, but heatshield showed visible improvements from past flights (see below).

What now? Next launch catalysts to watch:

- **Flight 14 (expected ~1 month out, late Aug / early Sept):** Shortly after Ship 40's splashdown, Musk posted that unless data review turns up problems, SpaceX will attempt to catch the Ship with the tower on the next flight. That would be the first-ever Ship catch on Mechazilla's arms at Starbase.
 - **Implies Starship's first orbital flight.** A tower Ship catch requires an orbital (not suborbital) trajectory, so Flight 14 would likely be Starship's first orbital attempt. Worth flagging: after 13 test flights and three years, SpaceX has yet to complete a full Earth orbit with Starship.
 - **Likely no V3 booster catch yet.** Given Flight 13's hard booster splashdown, SpaceX will want a clean soft splashdown of the new V3 booster before risking a catch, so Flight 14 should fly the booster to the water again.
 - **Potential first operational Starlink V3s.** Flight 13's 20 V3s were a suborbital demo that demised on reentry about 20 minutes after deployment. An orbital Flight 14 could theoretically deploy V3s into a working orbit for the first time, the first genuinely operational deployment.
- **Flight 15 (roughly a month after that):** If Flight 14 lands a Ship catch and a soft booster splashdown, Flight 15 could be the first to attempt a Ship catch and a V3 booster catch on the same mission.

See here for our SpaceX Initiation: [SpaceX: AI's Final Frontier; Initiate at Overweight, PT \\$300 \(7 Jul 2026\)](#)

Exhibit 1: Flight 13 Report Card

Starship Flight 13 Report Card

Final Grade

A-

Flight Test

Flight 13 (Ship 40 / Booster 20)

Date

July 24, 2026

Launch

Starbase, TX

Vehicle

Starship V3 (2nd flight)

Duration

~66 min, suborbital

Result

Dual splashdown; Ship intact

Flight Phase

Grade

01

Countdown & launch readiness
Recovered from a T-0 pad abort on Jul 16 (moisture in the LOX turbopumps kept four Raptors from starting; six engines swapped), then flew cleanly Jul 24. A Jul 23 weather scrub was outside SpaceX's control.

B

02

Liftoff & ascent
All 33 Super Heavy Raptors lit in a clean, full-thrust ascent with no engine-out.

✓A+

03

Hot-stage separation
Clean separation and stage split, with no repeat of the ~90° flip that doomed the Flight 12 booster.

✓A+

04

Boostback & landing burn
Boostback was clean, but the final landing burn lit only ~5 of 13 engines, forcing a hard splashdown in the Gulf of America. No catch was planned; a soft touchdown is a prerequisite before any future V3 tower catch.

C+
landing = weak spot

05

Payload deployment
First-ever deployment of 20 production Starlink V3s (prior flights flew simulators). Arrays and antennas extended; laser links to the constellation successful. Sats de-orbited as planned and imaged the ship's heat shield.

✓A+

06

In-space maneuvers / Raptor relight
Successful single-engine relight ~39 min into flight, completing the test abandoned on Flight 12 after a Raptor Vacuum engine was lost.

✓A+

07

Ship reentry, heat shield & splashdown
Cleared peak heating and max-Q, then SpaceX's softest splashdown ever; ship intact, floating and transmitting from the Indian Ocean, enabling imagery of nearly the entire heat shield. Some tile damage, but visible improvement over past flights.

✓A+
No explosion!

Comments

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Bears will isolate the off-nominal booster landing burn as reason for caution, but this was only the second landing attempt of a V3 booster and its all-new Raptor 3 propulsion, so a hard landing should not be a major surprise, and it still marked a clear step up from Flight 12 when the V3 booster was lost before it ever reached a landing. First lockup release after August 4 earnings is still an overhang which likely keeps many would-be longs on the sidelines.

Overall stock implications: Positive. Next milestone... catching ship. If they can do that, bears may need to consider cryogenic hibernation.

Catalysts to Watch

Flight 14 (targeted ~1 month out, late Aug / early Sept):

shortly after Ship 40's splashdown, Musk posted that unless data review turns up problems, SpaceX will attempt to catch the Ship with the tower, the first-ever Ship catch on Mechazilla's arms at Starbase.

Implies Starship's first orbital flight:

a tower Ship catch requires an orbital trajectory, so Flight 14 would likely be the first orbital attempt. After 13 flights and three years, SpaceX has yet to complete a full Earth orbit with Starship.

Likely no V3 booster catch yet:

given Flight 13's hard booster splashdown, SpaceX will want a clean soft splashdown of the new V3 booster first, so Flight 14 should fly the booster to the water again.

Potential first operational Starlink V3s:

Flight 13's 20 V3s were a suborbital demo that demised ~20 min after deployment; an orbital Flight 14 could deploy V3s into a working orbit for the first time.

Flight 15 (roughly a month later):

if Flight 14 lands a Ship catch and a soft booster splashdown, Flight 15 could be the first to attempt a Ship catch and a V3 booster catch on the same mission.

Flight 14/15 profiles are not yet officially confirmed by SpaceX; timing and catch sequencing are our estimates.

Source: Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 2: View of Ship 40 after Stage Separation



Source: SpaceX

Exhibit 3: Ship 40 Floating Intact in the Indian Ocean



Source: SpaceX

Valuation Methodology and Risks

SpaceX (SPCX.O)

Sum-of-the-Parts by Segment: Space, Connectivity, AI (Divided into X & Grok and Enterprise AI)

- \$300 Price Target = sum of Space (\$8), Connectivity (\$128), X & Grok (\$12), Enterprise AI (\$152)

2040 ending forecast period

6/30/2027 valuation date

11.1% WACC; 11.9% Cost of Equity

50% Enterprise AI valuation discount for execution risk

TGR of: 4.0% Space, 4.5% connectivity, 3.0% X & Grok, 5.0% Enterprise AI

Equates to 0.41 EV/EBIT/Growth

Risks to Upside

- Faster Starship reuse progress
- Faster Starlink capacity growth
- Stronger DTC / enterprise adoption
- More neocloud wins
- Cursor ARR acceleration
- Lower AI infrastructure time to power and cost

Risks to Downside

- Slower Starship reuse cadence
- Slower Starlink subscriber growth
- Weaker enterprise AI monetization
- Higher capex / cost per watt of compute
- Longer time-to-power
- Greater funding needs / dilution
- Regulatory delays

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(as of June 30, 2026)

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Stock Rating Category	Coverage Universe		Investment Banking Clients (IBC)			Other Material Investment Services Clients (MISC)	
	Count	% of Total	Count	% of Total IBC	% of Rating Category	Count	% of Total Other MISC
Overweight/Buy	1544	42%	453	49%	29%	757	44%
Equal-weight/Hold	1577	43%	390	42%	25%	769	44%
Not-Rated/Hold	3	0%	1	0%	33%	1	0%
Underweight/Sell	544	15%	89	10%	16%	204	12%
Total	3,668		933			1731	

Data include common stock and ADRs currently assigned ratings. Investment Banking Clients are companies from whom Morgan Stanley received investment banking compensation in the last 12 months. Due to rounding off of decimals, the percentages provided in the "% of total" column may not add up to exactly 100 percent.

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Stock Price, Price Target and Rating History (See Rating Definitions)

SpaceX (SPCX.O) - As of 07/27/26 GMT in USD
Industry : Space Technology



Stock Rating History: 7/7/26 : 0/A

Price Target History: 7/7/26 : 300

Source: Morgan Stanley Research Date Format : MM/DD/YY Price Target --- No Price Target Assigned (NA)

Stock Price (Not Covered by Current Analyst) — Stock Price (Covered by Current Analyst) —

Stock and Industry Ratings (abbreviations below) appear as ♦ Stock Rating/Industry View

Stock Ratings: Overweight (O) Equal-weight (E) Underweight (U) Not-Rated (NR) No Rating Available (NA)

Industry View: Attractive (A) In-line (I) Cautious (C) No Rating (NR)

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INDUSTRY COVERAGE: Space Technology

COMPANY (TICKER)	RATING (AS OF)	PRICE* (07/24/2026)
Adam Jonas, CFA		
SpaceX (SPCX.O)	O (07/07/2026)	\$115.07
Justin M Lang		

Gogo Inc (GOGO.O)	E (08/14/2025)	\$3.81
Iridium Communications Inc (IRDM.O)	E (01/16/2026)	\$45.78
MDA Space Ltd (MDA.TO)	O (01/16/2026)	C\$41.72
Viasat Inc (VSAT.O)	E (12/15/2017)	\$71.70
Kristine T Liwag		
Firefly Aerospace Inc (FLY.O)	E (09/02/2025)	\$19.69
HawkEye 360 Inc (HAWK.N)	O (06/01/2026)	\$19.38
Planet Labs PBC (PL.N)	E (01/22/2023)	\$20.47
Rocket Lab USA Inc (RKL.B.O)	O (01/16/2026)	\$63.91
Virgin Galactic Holdings Inc (SPCE.N)	U (11/22/2023)	\$2.49
Voyager Technologies Inc (VOYG.N)	U (07/15/2026)	\$25.24

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* Historical prices are not split adjusted.